Ashes of Elonia: Player Primer — New Player Edition

Everything in this handout is common knowledge. Your character grew up knowing most of it. Nothing in here spoils the mystery - it is what grandmothers, teachers, priests, and dockworkers all agree on.

New here? Section 9 catches you up on Sessions 1–3, Section 10 explains where the party is right now, and Section 11 covers character creation for a level-2 newcomer.

1. The World You Live In

One thousand years ago, the Nine Celestine - the gods - withdrew from the world. No priest can tell you why. The event is called the **Silence**, and every faith, university, and grandmother disagrees about what it meant.

What followed is undisputed history. For three hundred years civilization starved: aqueducts built for miracles ran dry, warded granaries failed, plague and famine walked openly, and the **Age of Ashes** killed on a scale the chronicles still won't number. Then mortals did what they do - they rebuilt. Without gods. Engineers raised waterwheels where prayers once sufficed. Physicians learned quarantine instead of invocation. Printers, lamp-lighters, canal-diggers, and charter-lawyers replaced miracle-workers. Five powers rose, and for seven centuries the world has been, by most measures, working.

You live in that world: **gas lamps and lecture halls, guild contracts and customs inspectors**, a continent that runs on law, coin, and ingenuity - built directly on top of a buried age it barely understands.

2. What People Think They Know

Most of the old history is *lost*. That is the point - the book that remembers it enters the story later. Here is how much your character actually starts with:

What every child knows (common myth). Once, the gods walked among mortals and the world was full of wonders. Then the gods left - the Silence - and everything broke. Cities fell, millions died, and mortals had to learn to live without rescue. That is the whole of it in most households: *there were gods, they left, we survived.* Details blur into sermon and song. A dockworker "knows" the gods built everything; a farmer "knows" they punished us; a League schoolchild "knows" they sheltered us too long. All three are certain. None of them agree.

What the educated know (fragments). If your character had schooling, a temple education, or a Lyceum primer, add scraps: there was once a partnership between gods and rulers, not slavery to them. There were great cities of the divine age - Solcaris of laws, Ilyanor of books, a drowned or burned city of mercy with no walls. Scholars name more, and argue about every name. A late mortal movement of physicians and engineers tried to make hospitals and granaries work without miracles - ancestors of modern artifice, honored and faintly distrusted. Something went wrong in their deepest workshops; respectable histories change the subject. A bright late city is remembered as a moral warning - rich, wise, and cruel all at once - but its name, dates, and guilt are debated in footnotes, not taught to children.

What is lost (what play will reveal). The names of valleys and councils, the wording of old oaths, the true shape of the Nine Cities, what the questioners actually built, and why the gods really divided - none of this is common knowledge. Whole reigns and workshops are missing from the record, and specialists disagree whether the gaps are accident, censorship, or rot. The book that remembers - the *Ain Elonar* - is not in your character's hands at the start. When it enters the story, it will contradict things in this primer. That is intentional. Trust what you find in play over what you read here.

Rule for the table: if it is in Section 2's first paragraph, your character knows it. If it is in the second paragraph, you know it only with schooling or a relevant background. If it is anything more precise, your character has at best heard a garbled version - and may be wrong.

3. The Nine, As Ordinary People Tell Them

Nobody worships all Nine anymore. Most people honor one, respect two or three, and ignore the rest. Priests will tell you the gods were vast and constrained at once - each bound to its own nature. Aurelion *could not* act against law; Iskara *could not* choose indifference. Mortals, being bound to nothing in particular, surprised them daily. Whether that delighted or frightened them depended on the god.

Here is the street version - titles, stories, and how each faith looks at your table:

Myrraen, the Last Mercy

The Weeping Dawn, the Unbroken Shield

- **Domains:** mercy, healing, sanctuary, protection, conscience.
- **Old stories:** last of the Nine to wake - found standing by a river, saying *"I have seen pain."* Founded hospitals and refuges wherever she walked. Founded **Vale Myrr**, the unwalled sanctuary-city: *"Those who seek shelter should never meet a gate."* Vale Myrr burned in the Ashes. People still argue about what that proved.
- **Today:** the largest charitable faith. Grey vestments, hospices, soup kitchens, plague wards, penitent orders. One parish reads the Silence as mercy, the next as punishment; they argue with each other constantly.
- **At the table:** Life and Peace clerics, Redemption paladins. A Myrraenic novice carries bandages before holy symbols. Ask your cleric: does your parish preach mercy, judgment, or liberation?
- **Saying:** *"Mercy is faith that people can become better than they are."*

Aurelion, the Sovereign Flame

The Lawgiver, the Golden Aegis, the Sun of Solcaris

- **Domains:** law, civilization, order, civic duty, the sun, architecture.
- **Old stories:** first teacher of kings and judges; taught that rulers themselves could answer to written law. Raised **Solcaris**, city of white walls, courts, and senate domes. Opposed the Silence to the end - a parent does not stop guiding a child because the child resents guidance.
- **Today:** ideological heart of the **Aurelian League** and the austere **Keepers of Dawn**, who keep the old rites polished in case the sky answers. Judges, magistrates, legion officers, and tax collectors invoke him weekly.
- **At the table:** Order and Light clerics, Devotion and Crown paladins. An Aurelian acolyte knows court procedure better than scripture.
- **Saying:** *"The law must be stronger than the king who enforces it."*

Selyra, the Moonmother

The Weaver of Paths, the Silver Eye, the Sleepless Seer

- **Domains:** prophecy, dreams, night, stars, navigation, possibility.
- **Old stories:** dreamt the stars into being, say the songs. Founded dream-sanctuaries and the roofless observatories of **Nythara**, where seers read still pools. Late in the divine age she vanished for nine days and returned changed - never again speaking of the future with confidence. What she saw, she would not fully tell. Her one warning survives: *"Not all doors remain closed because they are locked."*
- **Today:** sailors, navigators, and astronomers whisper to her crescent. The reclusive **Dreamkeepers of Nythara** guard her ruined observatories. Everyone else treats prophecy as weather - respected, never trusted.
- **At the table:** Twilight and Knowledge clerics, Stars druids, Divination wizards who leave offerings "just in case." A Selyran vision never gives orders - only possibilities.
- **Saying:** *"The future speaks constantly. Most people prefer not to listen."*

Thaeron, the Iron Heart

The Unbroken Anvil, the Shield of Winters, Lord of the Crucible

- **Domains:** courage, discipline, endurance, struggle, protection through strength.
- **Old stories:** never a god of conquest - a god of *courage*. Taught warriors that strength means defending others, not dominating them. Raised **Harad Veyr** in the northern crags, where every citizen trained, every commander swore binding conduct-oaths, and statues honored those who held the line or carried the wounded out - never those who conquered.
- **Today:** soldiers, smiths, miners, frontier pioneers, legion shock units, and Iron Heart gymnasia where students drill before dawn. Shrines are plain iron anvils worn smooth by work - no gold.
- **At the table:** War and Forge clerics, Glory and Conquest paladins, Battle Master fighters who quote him. A Thaeronic oath always names *who* you will stand in front of.
- **Saying:** *"Strength has meaning because hardship exists."*

Elyndra, the Verdant Queen

The Deep Root, the Green Mother, Lady of Seasons

- **Domains:** nature, fields, forests, beasts, seasons, balance, decay.
- **Old stories:** cared little for thrones and much for soil. Never raised one great capital - raised networks of living settlements in harmony with forest and river. Taught rotation, grafting, and restraint. Her worship survived the Silence better than most, because the fields remained.
- **Today:** the living faith of **the Verdancy** - grovewardens, harvest offerings, solstice moots - and every sensible farmer's planting calendar anywhere else. Views brass engines and forced rivers as insults.
- **At the table:** Nature clerics, Land and Shepherd druids, rangers of any stripe. An Elyndran carries seeds alongside spell components.
- **Saying:** *"Humanity is part of nature, not separate from it."*

Varek, Keeper of the Final Door

The Grey Shepherd, Lord of Endings, Master of the Threshold

- **Domains:** death, passage, memory, funerals, the preservation of names.
- **Old stories:** came in silence - before him, say the myths, nothing truly ended. Taught that endings give things shape: a leaf is beautiful because it will never exist again. Raised the great **Houses of Remembrance**, where the names of the dead were kept so faithfully that bloodlines can still be traced through surviving fragments. First among the gods to warn that something was going wrong in the deepest workshops of the Ascensionists.
- **Today:** spiritual patron of the **Dominion of Vareth** and its **Custodians**, who engrave every lineage, virtue, and debt on stone. Every power borrows his funeral customs: name them, bury them, remember them.
- **At the table:** Grave clerics, Watchers paladins, necromancy-abjuring wizards who insist - loudly - that they are *shepherds, not raisers*. A Varekite's holy work is paperwork: names, dates, witnesses.
- **Saying:** *"A thing without an ending has no shape."*

Orinth, the Laughing Sage

The Lantern Bearer, the First Awakened, Master of Questions

- **Domains:** knowledge, invention, language, curiosity, laughter, skepticism.
- **Old stories:** first of the Nine to wake, who named the stone, the wind, and the sea - and began to understand them by naming. Spent his ages among mortals disguised as a scholar, arguing for days. Raised **Ilyanor**, greatest library-city ever known, where philosophers debated beggars and apprentices were taught to challenge their masters. Delighted when students questioned the gods themselves.
- **Today:** revered at the **Grand Lyceum**, among cartographers, artificers, and cryptographers. His tiny monastic friends, the **Church of the Last Light**, keep lanterns lit in forgotten places and ask for nothing. Students toast him before examinations and blame him after.
- **At the table:** Knowledge and Trickery clerics, Lore bards, wizards of every school. An Orinthine carries more questions than answers and lends books unasked.
- **Saying:** *"No question offends him except the refusal to ask one."*

Iskara, the Red Heart

The Flame of Devotion, Lady of Oaths, the Bondkeeper

- **Domains:** love, loyalty, passion, sworn bonds, sacrifice, emotional truth.
- **Old stories:** while other gods judged kingdoms, she judged individuals - sat at wedding fires, comforted grieving parents, counted the hunter who carried a companion out of danger as outweighing a thousand crimes. Raised river-cities of bridges and flame-arches where festivals, adoptions, and remembrances were formalized into law. Pleaded for compassion toward victims and perpetrators alike when the gods divided.
- **Today:** invoked at every wedding, vigil, blood-oath, and covenant-signing. Her roadside shrines hang twin braided red cords over embers. Couples, sworn siblings, and mercenary companies in need of trust all pay her respects.
- **At the table:** Light and Peace clerics, Devotion paladins, bards who sing at the feast rather than the court. An Iskaran oath is personal - sworn to *someone*, not to an idea.
- **Saying:** *"What matters is what you will suffer for."*

Kaelis, the Wandering Star

The Open Road, the Sea-Strider, the Breath of Dawn

- **Domains:** freedom, travel, exploration, luck, change, the horizon.
- **Old stories:** woke at the world's farthest edge and immediately started walking somewhere else. Hinted at passes, winds, and currents; explorers who followed found oceans and ranges no one believed crossable. Taught that uncertainty is not a danger but the source of meaning - and that freedom must include the freedom to make terrible mistakes, or it is only supervised obedience.
- **Today:** patron of sailors, cartographers, privateers, smugglers, runaways, and rebels along the **Free Coast**. Shrines are plain wooden compass roses at crossroads and lighthouses, often decorated without permission.
- **At the table:** Tempest and Trickery clerics, Ancients paladins, scouts, sailors, and anyone whose background includes the word "escaped." A Kaelite's blessing is practical: a fair wind, a loose knot, a guard looking the other way.
- **Saying:** *"Stagnation is the only true ruin."*

4. Faith Without Answers

The gods are silent and have been for a millennium. What remains:

- **The Myrraenic Faith and penitent orders.** The largest charitable faith - grey vestments, hospices, soup kitchens, plague wards. Reads the Silence as mercy in some parishes, punishment in others. Argues with itself constantly.
- **The Keepers of Dawn.** Austere orders keeping the old rites polished - swept temples, recited hours, maintained calendars - in case the sky ever answers. Strongest in the Aurelian League.
- **The Church of the Last Light.** A tiny fellowship that tends candles in forgotten places - roadside shrines, ruined chapels, unmarked graves - and asks for nothing. People like them without quite knowing why.
- **The university position.** Taught at the Grand Lyceum and repeated in every dockside debate: the Silence was liberation. Humanity grew up. Time to stop waiting for rescue.
- **Dockside superstition.** Charms against drowned bells, salt over the shoulder, coins for the ferryman, names spoken aloud on death anniversaries so the dead "find the road."
- **The fringe preachers.** A handful of ragged prophets say the gods are about to return. Respectable people call that the **Taboo of Return** and change the subject. It embarrasses priests, annoys professors, and draws crowds in bad winters.

Divine magic exists but it is rare and personal: a cleric's conviction, a paladin's oath, a grandmother's funeral rite that works for reasons no faculty will certify. No deity answers back. What answers, if anything, is between you and the DM.

The dead. Every culture honors Varek's old rule: name them, bury them, remember them. Lately there are ugly rumors - a dockworker's shadow that would not lie down, a grandmother knocking three nights after burial, graves found disturbed from the *inside* in Vareth. The Custodians call it fever-talk. Sailors cross themselves anyway.

5. The Five Powers

An uneasy peace called the **Concord of Meridian** prevents open continental war. Beneath it: tariffs, spies, smugglers, and a furious quiet competition over who owns the buried past.

- **The Free Coast.** Independent harbor-cities grown rich on trade and salvage. Loud, pragmatic, lightly governed by an **Admiralty Board** and bickering guilds. Your home for now: **Port Meridian**, population ~65,000, built on layered ruins it sells by the ounce. Coin matters more than blood here - a dragonborn captain, a tiefling salvager, and a human factor drink at the same table, provided all three pay their tabs.
- **The Republic of Ilya.** A state run by its university. The **Grand Lyceum** at **New Ilya** - built over the ruins of Ilyanor - sets curriculum, currency policy, and what counts as history. Degrees are social rank. Floating lecture halls crowd the canals; patent offices are busier than temples. Ilya's official line: the Silence set humanity free, and inquiry will finish the job. If you want a fact certified, you go to Ilya. If you want a fact buried, someone in Ilya already filed it.
- **The Aurelian League.** Sun-plains heartland of legions, highways, and magistrates. Order, duty, solar eagles. Capital: **Solcaris Nova**, raised beside the ruins of old Solcaris, all white plazas and triumphal arches. The **Prefecture of Antiquities** confiscates unapproved relics. The League's sermons say: keep the civic flame pure and the golden age may return.

- **The Verdancy.** Rain-canopy communes under colossal ironwoods, governed by moots of **grovewardens**. Timber, medicine, and a standing refusal to be ruled. Lineage means nothing here; carrying brass clockwork into a grove means everything - hostile everything. The League's lumber syndicates keep testing the border. The border keeps objecting.
- **The Dominion of Vareth.** Desert canyon-cities of black basalt where the dead outnumber the living sixty to one. The **Custodians** record every birth and death on monumental stone tablets; your legal standing is your pedigree's depth. They do not raise the dead - they *keep* them. Their ledgers, lately, will not close, and League quarantine planners have noticed.

6. How the World Actually Works

Technology. Think late-industrial ingenuity without electricity or gunpowder-as-you-know-it: gas lamps, printing presses, waterwheels and counterweight cranes, canal locks, navigational chronometers, siege engines, alchemical laboratories, messenger-semaphore lines between great cities. The strange stuff is **artifice** - salvaged or reverse-engineered Pre-Silence brass-and-glass machinery - and **arcana**, the mortal magic rebuilt after the Silence through study rather than prayer.

Magic. Arcane magic is a university discipline with guild licenses, laboratory accidents, and published treatises. Druidic and ancestral traditions persist outside the lecture halls. Divine magic is the outlier - rare, unlicensed by any faculty, and faintly embarrassing to professors. Warlocks exist and are gossiped about: everyone agrees they hold a bargain with *something* in the dark - a ruin, a court, a voice. Nobody agrees on what.

Money, law, and movement. Coin is continental: League suns, Lyceum marks, Coast sails, Vareth tablets-of-exchange - all honored at any guildhouse for a fee. Written contracts bind; Admiralty courts and League magistrates enforce them briskly. Travel runs by cog-ship, river barge, League highway, and (for the rich or desperate) Ilya skyship. Papers matter at every border. Bribes matter more.

The lifespan chasm. This shapes every argument about the gods. For humans (and halflings, and orcs), the Silence is forty generations back - myth. For dwarves and gnomes, it is heirloom-memory - five to eight generations. For elves, it is *grief*: a living elder's grandmother walked the avenues of Solcaris or studied under Orinth in Ilyanor. Humans call elder folk paralyzed by nostalgia. Elder folk call humans amnesiac children playing with matches around a ruin they don't understand. Both are rude. Both have a point.

Salvage. Pre-Silence vaults, transit tubes, and scriptoriums honeycomb the bedrock under every modern city. Digging them up is one of the continent's great industries and a standing political problem. Finds belong to whoever holds the charter, the permit, and the muscle, roughly in that order. The black market pays better and asks nothing. That discount always collects.

7. The Peoples of Elonia

Humans are the majority (~55%) everywhere except the canopy and the necropolis. Nobody stares at halflings, gnomes, dwarves, elves, dragonborn, or beastfolk in a Coast port - Port Meridian runs on all of them. Constructs draw a glance and then a shrug; changelings draw a glance and then a second one.

- **Humans.** The restless rebuilders. Dominant in the League, Ilya, and the Coast. Impatient, ambitious, everywhere.
- **Elves.** The echo-bearers (~10%). River/high elves hold Lyceum chairs and archive desks and suffer a recognized sadness scholars call *the Melancholy* - grief for a song they barely remember. Canopy/wood elves keep the Verdancy's groves and want no part of your salvage charter.
- **Dwarves.** The anvil-keepers (~12%). Iron-bound smiths and legion engineers in the west; grave-masons in Vareth whose vaults outlast dynasties. Contracts, lineage, craft.
- **Halflings & gnomes.** The hearth and the clockwork (~11%). Halfling riverfolk run barges, farms, and hospitality across Ilya and the Coast. Gnomes make chronometers, ciphers, and salvage rigs, and are the only scholars who handle Ascensionist wreckage without flinching.
- **Dragonborn.** Descendants of the Elder Era (~4%). Clan-centered coastal and mountain keeps. They regard the Celestine as latecomers and human politics as entertainment. Prized as marines and alchemists.
- **Tieflings - the ash-born.** Not fiend-spawn in any story worth repeating. Folk wisdom says they are children born near bad places - ruin-zones, ether fractures, laboratory misfires - marked by horns, tails, and strange eyes. The League makes them register. Ilya wants them to sign research waivers. Vareth pities them. The Coast hires them as navigators and salvagers and calls them lucky.
- **Aasimar - the dawn-echoes.** Very rare. Born with a faint radiance, an old harmonic the nurses can't explain. The Keepers of Dawn revere them. Daily life mostly alienates them.

- **Beastfolk, orcs, and frontier folk.** Canopy communes, pirate flotillas, legion shock units, deep mines. Thaeron's old lesson follows them: *struggle creates dignity.* Bugbears, goblins, and hobgoblins are beastfolk here, not monsters - a bugbear dockhand is unremarkable in the Warrens, and a hobgoblin drill-sergeant is a normal sight on a League parade ground.
- **Constructs - the brass-born.** Rare, and recent. Foundry-built labour for ruin-work, mining, and salvage, because a construct can be sent where a person cannot and does not need to be paid. Warforged, autognomes, and one-off foundry frames all fall under this. Most are tools with a voice. A few are not, and nobody agrees on when that happens, what causes it, or whether it is a fault to be repaired. The Coast hires them and calls them lucky. Ilya wants to study them. The League wants to know who owns them. If you play one, decide who built you - and whether they are still looking.
- **Changelings - the borrowed faces.** Rare, and rarely announced. No homeland, no guild, no parish: a changeling is whoever the room needs. Port Meridian's customs service fears them, employs them, and denies doing either. Most changelings keep two or three faces and a real one for people they trust, which is a short list.

Anything rarer than the above needs a one-line explanation and the DM's agreement.

8. Port Meridian: Your City (For Now)

The smell first: brine, pitch, gutted cod, tar, lamp-oil, ambition. Salt-crusted timber wharves lean against Pre-Silence sea-walls of dark cyclopean basalt. Crane-rigs rattle overhead. Gulls scream. Somebody is always singing, suing, or unloading.

Who runs it. The **Admiralty Board** (customs, courts, navy, lockups) and the **Harbor Guilds** (money, warehouses, cranes, permits). They feud the way old married couples feud - constantly, and united against outsiders.

Districts you'll actually use:

1. **The Gilded Docks & Admiralty Wharf.** Floating piers, drydocks, customs sheds. League galleons and Ilya river-barges unload grain, timber, wine, and contraband side by side. The **Salt-Lantern Tavern** - run by Bess, a retired tiefling privateer - is where crews are hired and expeditions leak.
2. **The Salvage Warrens.** Bonded warehouses, foundries, tenements. The job that started all this: **Warehouse Nine**, factor Helena Voss's cavernous depot of rope, timber, and iron spikes - with a sealed fault beneath the cellar floor. Half the Warrens is built over plugged vault mouths. Everyone knows. Nobody maps them honestly.
3. **The Antiquities Exchange.** Colonnaded plaza of auction houses, pawn-brokers, appraisers, and notaries. Legal finds are certified here. Illegal finds are fenced three streets over for twice the price and ten times the risk. The elite appraisal house **The Brass Astrolabe** employs junior archivists who can read the old script.
4. **The Lower Reefs.** At low tide, drowned Pre-Silence arches and plazas surface in Meridian Bay. Beautiful. Lootable at low water. Lethal via rip-tides, razor barnacles, and reef-crawlers nesting in drainpipes.
5. **The Admiralty Citadel.** Black basalt fortress on the southern promontory. Courts upstairs, garrison in the middle, lockup cells below - where unlicensed diggers wait to be fined or impressed into the navy.

Powers you'll brush against (street version):

- **Licensed factors** (like Helena Voss) hold charters and pay wages.
- **The Admiralty** holds the law and the cells.
- **The Archive Cartels** hold the dark alleys and the better prices. Name to know: **Vance Rorik**. If his sellswords are watching your dig, you are either competition or inventory.
- **The Ascendants** hold lecture halls and pamphlets. Publicly: historians, archaeologists, and reformers who say lost history belongs to everyone. Half the Lyceum laughs at them; the other half funds them. Their local circle meets above a chandler's shop and argues about pottery shards until midnight.
- **Missionaries and professors** drift through on League or Lyceum business and condescend to everyone equally.

The law that will matter to you. The charter writ covers *salvage* - rope, copper, worked stone. Anything that looks like *antiquities* (seals, codices, star-charts, reliquaries, anything with writing or worship on it) belongs to the Admiralty unless certified at the Exchange. Unlicensed relics mean fines or naval impressment. The Cartels will offer you a better price in a darker alley. That is your decision to make.

9. The Story So Far (Sessions 1–3)

What follows is what the party knows at the end of Session 3. It is written for a new player: no secrets the table hasn't earned, and no hints about what comes next.

The job

Helena Voss, a licensed salvage factor, hired four down-on-their-luck adventurers for a three-day contract at **Warehouse Nine** in the Salvage Warrens: clear vermin, shore timber, and map a collapsed fault beneath the cellar. The pay was **15 gold each plus a tenth-share of certified scrap** - legal, licensed, and the kind of job every salvager over thirty warns you about while ordering another drink.

With them came **Arlen Marr**, a junior archivist from the Brass Astrolabe who could read the old script and could not fight at all. Arlen was certain the vault below was a cult shrine. He was wrong.

What was under the warehouse

The first night went wrong before they were even underground. Someone had **sliced the warehouse rope** - deliberately, in a hurry, and not by the Breakers. The party went down anyway and left the hatch open behind them.

Below, they found not a death cult but a **civic archive**: grain ledgers, municipal codes, statues of scholars measuring the stars. No altars. No skulls. Arlen's worldview took a visible dent. They fought cellar rats, a pair of centipedes, and - in the Hall of Records - a **ghoul**.

The ghoul nearly killed Bog. It did take a leg from a dying Breaker named **Tamsin Roke**, whom Dan saved with *Spare the Dying*. Zook built Tamsin a peg leg, the party took a long rest in the dark, and Tamsin has travelled with them ever since.

They also found a chest in the dust - ordinary, despite everyone's suspicions - and an eyepatch that turned out to be a **mimic**. Bog put it on, made his save, threw it off, and it escaped into the Hall. It is still down there somewhere.

The Scriptorium

At the bottom of the archive stood a **brass door**, sealed for a thousand years. Someone modern had already been picking it - the party found both halves of a snapped steel lockpick. Bog ripped the second half out, the seal failed, and dry air flooded in. The loose paper in the Scriptorium crumbled to dust. The **Oath**, cut into stone, survived.

Beyond the door they found **Wren**, Tamsin's survey partner, dead - **his soul ripped out**. Tamsin recognised him. Dan took his coat, which is, objectively, a very cool coat.

In the cellar they captured another Breaker - not Wren - and took from him the **Catalogue Index Tablet**, a loose leaf of ledger, and a **Bag of Holding**. They handed him alive to the magistrates. Then the ceiling came down. Everyone got out, including the prisoner, and the Scriptorium sealed itself behind them.

The surface

On the surface, the party caught **Arlen** carrying something he called **"the precious stone"** - not the Tablet. Helena questioned him; the party made him throw it back into the collapse. Arlen then **confessed**: the Exchange masters had told him to log the archive as cult debris and sell the vellum by weight, and he had refused. He left after a petty threat, looking like a man going to his own funeral. He is not a villain. He is a proud, frightened man who did the right thing badly.

Helena glimpsed the party's loot and let it go. The session ended in a Port Meridian pub - everyone except Arlen, with Tamsin at the table and the Tablet in their keeping.

Where things stand

- **The party is level 2.** They have money, a little gear, and a great deal of attention.
- **The Catalogue Index Tablet is in their hands.** It is old, it is covered in star-charts and script, and it is the reason Chapter 2 happens.
- **Tamsin Roke travels with them.** A Breaker with a peg leg, a dead partner, and a target on his back. He was not handed over to the magistrates.
- **Wren is dead, his soul ripped out.** Tamsin talks about **"glass-faced ghosts."** Nobody has explained them.
- **Arlen is gone** - humiliated, not evil, and possibly recoverable.
- **An unnamed Breaker is in the Admiralty lockup.** He knows who sent him.
- **The mimic is loose** somewhere under the city.
- **Helena's charter is under strain**, and the **Archive Cartels** have noticed the party.

The party you'd be joining

Player	Character	Class / Species	In one line
Dan	IRC-10414 "Wanderer"	Twilight Cleric, Warforged	The party's darkvision, healer, and conscience. Wears Wren's coat.
James	Zook Scheppen Clang	Artificer, Rock Gnome	Shopper, tinkerer, builder of peg legs (apparently). Hoards copper with conviction.
Kit	John Fantasy	Warlock, Changeling	Wears a pink protective scarf.
Theo	Bogbrir "Bog"	Monk, Bugbear	Drunk for most of the first delve, unkillable when it counts. Caught John Fantasy mid-fall.

10. Your Situation

Date: **c. 1,000 AS**. Place: **Port Meridian**, the morning after Session 3. Rain on the windows, salt in the gutters, and a great deal of unfinished business.

You are joining at the start of **Chapter 2**. The party is level 2, Tamsin is with them, Arlen has vanished, and the Tablet needs translating before the Cartels work out where the next door is.

How you fit in - pick one with the DM, or bring your own:

- **Extra muscle.** Helena Voss is short on people she trusts and long on problems. She hires you for the road.
- **A friend of Tamsin's.** Another Breaker, a dockhand, a surveyor - someone who knew Wren and wants answers.
- **An Ascendant.** The local circle meets above a chandler's shop. They have been waiting for proof like the Tablet for years.
- **A fellow salvager.** You have worked the Warrens, you know the law, and you know the Cartels pay better than the law does.
- **A Lyceum-trained scholar.** You can read more Old Elonian than Arlen can, and you have the student debt to prove it.

What you bring is up to you. The party has a cleric, an artificer, a warlock, and a monk - but gaps are cheaper than redundancy, and this campaign rewards people who can talk, climb, and keep a secret.

The job is legal, licensed, and - as every salvager over thirty will tell you while ordering another drink - exactly the kind of job where things stop being legal around hour six.

11. Making a Character

- **System:** D&D 5th Edition, **2024 rules** (the 2024 *Player's Handbook*), starting at **level 2** to match the party. Advancement is by story milestones, not by counting kills.
- **Monsters:** the DM uses the **2014 *Monster Manual*** and the stat blocks in this campaign's files. If a monster's wording differs between printings, the DM's block wins.
- **Ability scores:** Standard array, point buy, or rolled - table's choice, same method for all.
- **Hit points:** Max at 1st level, then fixed average thereafter (no rolling).
- **Origin feats.** Every 2024 background grants one origin feat. Take it; it is part of your build, not a bonus. Your background also sets your ability score increases - if you want a different spread, say so before play and the DM will allow a swap.
- **Weapon Mastery.** Martial classes get mastery properties at 1st level. Track which weapon has which property on your sheet; the DM will ask.
- **Multiclassing and feats:** allowed, as written. No optional flanking, no variant encumbrance. Potions may be drunk as a bonus action; feeding one to someone else is an action.
- **Peoples:** Humans are the majority everywhere. Halflings, gnomes, dwarves, elves, dragonborn, beastfolk (including orcs, goblins, and bugbears), tieflings, and constructs are ordinary citizens of Port Meridian. Changelings and aasimar are rarer and draw a second look. Anything rarer needs a one-line explanation and the DM's agreement.

- **Classes:** All official options. A few setting notes, not restrictions:
    - *Fighters, rogues, rangers:* guild guards, customs officers, privateers, salvagers, reef-runners. You fit everywhere.
    - *Wizards, artificers, bards (College of Lore):* Lyceum graduates, foundry apprentices, guild cipher-clerks, Vane-funded laboratories. Your diploma is a social weapon.
    - *Clerics, paladins:* servants of an *interpretation* of a silent god. No deity answers back. Pick what your character believes the Silence meant - mercy, punishment, liberation, mystery - and know the parish down the street disagrees.
    - *Druids, barbarians:* Verdancy moots, frontier communes, reef-tribes, Vareth outriders. The city thinks you're picturesque. The city is wrong.
    - *Sorcerers:* ether-fracture births, ruin-zone inheritances, old blood. Ilya wants to study you. The League wants you registered. The Coast wants to hire you.
    - *Warlocks:* you hold a bargain with something in the dark - a ruin, a court, a voice, worse. Define it with the DM; assume your character's theory of what it is could be wrong.
    - *Monks:* cloistered orders, penitent houses, Iron Heart gymnasia, Last Light chapels. Every power has one quiet courtyard where people train before dawn.
- **Alignment:** No evil player characters. The campaign is about hard choices; the party needs to be people who wrestle with them, not people who cause them for fun.
- **Backgrounds:** Any, reskinned to the Coast - take the 2024 background and rename it to fit. Urchins grew up in the Warrens. Acolytes swept a Dawn chapel or a Myrraenic ward. Sages carry Lyceum letters. Sailors know Bess by name. Criminals know Rorik's lieutenants by reputation and prefer it stays that way. If no printed background fits, build one with the DM: two skills, one tool, one origin feat, and an ability spread.
- **Starting gear:** Standard class equipment, plus one salvage tool (crowbar, climber's kit, healer's kit, or scholar's pack). One personal item with no value and no mechanics - a letter, a chit, a dead parent's nail, a pressed ironwood leaf - is encouraged.
- **Languages:** Common plus any standard choice. Old Elonian (the script of the buried age) is *not* available at 1st level except via a background that grants it, the DM's permission, or a very good reason in your backstory - otherwise you pay the Brass Astrolabe to translate for you.